

Ἀλκιδάμας ὁ Ἐλαεύς

Alcidamas of Elaea on the Rhetoric of Odysseus

eul_aid: dkm

Period: [Κλασική](#) [Classical](#)

Dialect: [Ἀττική](#) [Attic](#)

Domain: [Ῥητορική](#) [Oratory](#)

Format: [Λόγος](#) [Oration](#)

Affiliation: [Sophist](#)

Alcidamas was a Greek teacher of rhetoric and a sophist from the late 5th to early 4th century BCE. He was a student of the famous sophist Gorgias and taught in Athens, where he was a contemporary and rival of the orator Isocrates. His career represents the traveling professional sophists of the Classical period who offered instruction in persuasive speaking.

His surviving work is limited. The most complete text is a speech titled "On the Sophists," which argues for the superiority of skilled, improvisational speaking over delivering pre-written speeches. A second work, a fragmentary declamation called "Odysseus," also survives. Other works attributed to him are lost.

Alcidamas is historically important for his role in a major debate about rhetorical practice. His treatise "On the Sophists" is a key document defending spontaneity and flexibility in oratory as more authentic for real political and legal situations. His fragmentary "Odysseus" speech is seen as an early example of a mythological exercise that became standard in later rhetorical training. His arguments about the limits of written texts also provide an interesting contrast to philosophical critiques of writing from the same era.

Works (1)

- [Ὀδυσσεύς](#) · [Odysseus](#) · 50 passages

Other Sophist Authors

- [Ἀχιλλεύς ὁ Τατίος ὁ Ἀλεξανδρεύς](#) · [Achilles Tatiuss of Alexandria](#) · 1 work
- [Κλαύδιος Αἰλιανός](#) · [Aelian of Praeneste](#) · 4 works
- [Πόπλιος Αἴλιος Ἀριστείδης Θεόδωρος](#) · [Aelius Aristides of Smyrna](#) · 3 works
- [Αἴλιος Διονύσιος ὁ Ἀλικαρνασσεύς](#) · [Aelius Dionysius of Halicarnassus](#) · 1 work
- [Αἴλιος Θεών ὁ σοφιστής](#) · [Aelius Theon the Sophist](#) · 1 work
- [Ἀλκίφων ὁ Σοφιστής](#) · [Alciphron the Sophist](#) · 1 work
- [Ἀλέξανδρος ὁ τοῦ Νουμήνιου](#) · [Alexander Son of Numenius](#) · 2 works
- [Ἀλέξανδρος ὁ Ἐφέσιος](#) · [Alexander the Ephesian Poet](#) · 1 work
- [Ἀμφικράτης Ἀθηναῖος](#) · [Amphicrates Atheniensis](#) · 1 work
- [Ἀνώνυμος ὑπόμνημα εἰς Ἀφθόνιον](#) · [Anonymous Commentary on Aphthonius](#) · 2 works
- [Ἀντιφῶν ὁ Ἀθηναῖος](#) · [Antiphon of Athens](#) · 9 works

- Ἀντιφῶν ὁ Ῥαμνούσιος · Antiphon of Rhamnus · 1 work